Minutes of NZRA General Meeting
Christchurch, Monday 2 December 2013

Present: Pete Squires, Bill Kennedy, Grant Hunter, Trevor Merrifield, Mondo Kopua, Douglas Woods
Apologies: Emma de Lacey, Jamie Stuart

Agenda

1. National and regional framework for NZRA
2. National championships 2014, 15, 16 – dates, venues, organisers
3. Other

National and regional framework for NZRA.

Background and the need for change
Widely agreed at the meeting that the Association continues to struggle to actively support rogaining at regional and local levels across much of the country. Examples include slowness to confirm organisers/dates/venues for national champs, including a failure to stage a championship event in 2013, and a lack of a strategy for financially investing in promoting rogaining.

The national secretary outlined his experience of the need for different approaches for local/regional versus national activities, arising from difficulties he has setting agendas, communication loops, etc. The committee comprises a core membership plus regional representatives. In practice, general committee meetings tend to be attended only by Canterbury participants and we lack a framework for the across-regional interaction, other than by linear-based emails. The latter are clumsy and inefficient for making decisions.

Key realities and limitations
1.People have limited time. Most rogaine leaders are focussed on local events and personal interests in the sport. Few have the outlook to consistently engage in national needs. This means:

- Systems and demands must be kept simple, by keeping overall needs simple and modest, and/or breaking up the loads and sharing them.
- New leaders are needed to invigorate (and soon-enough replace) the current complement, particularly younger ages
- A more balanced regional spread of active leadership is needed.

2.We have poor tools and ability for networking at a range of geographical scales. We need to network effectively at and between regional and national levels - electronic media provide the required opportunities.

Needed: a volunteer willing to become familiar with such tools, to propose a mix that will meet the Associations needs and to assist with their uptake. (This assumes that those who need to join such dialogue are personally willing to engage with suitable tools.)

Douglas Wood volunteered to organise an e-meetings tool, at least to get us started. (Sec - this should be implemented for the AGM in late February 2014.)

3.Many specialist roles across the committee are ill-defined and/or not allocated to a responsible person or group. Roles appearing to need review include

- Coordinator, national champs and of national rules and standards
- Coordination of financial investment in regaining (may need to be a group rather than an individual)
- Communication with Internatiomal Rogaining Federation. We have two reps on IRF but there is no regular feedback between IRF and NZRA except on specific active topics that capture wide attention.

Noted that some specialist roles operate very effectively, e.g., website/newsletter, Navlight management. (Both will, sooner or later, need succession.)

Suggestions for a new structure

A complementary national & regional/local presence is suggested. These must have (1) simplicity, (2) load sharing, and (3) effective interconnections between them.

National presence

- Revamp the current NZRA national committee into a smaller core of retainers who have regional as well as national interests. A suggested grouping is one rep from each self-defined 'active' region (SI: currently Marlborough/Nelson, Canterbury, Otago (the later could choose to break into say Central and Dunedin); maybe plus one person from each island not aligned to an active region.
- Sec, treasurer, editor etc can either be chosen from the regional reps or co-opted from a region (see also 'A paid national sec/treasurer', below)

Roles (include):

- Coordinate national champs
- Links with IRF, NZ rules
- Coordinate across regions
- Operate PL insurance and ensure other legal and other professional needs and bottom lines are met (e.g. safety planning)
- Invest/allocate central funds to promote rogaining, including enabling regional/local events
- Support/endorse regional groups for funding applications
- Operate national website/newsletter – or allocate out to a regional person
- Tools, resources, training....
- Report annually as an incorporated society

Regional/local perspective

- Those regions seeking to identify themselves as a local 'group', including having a bank account for organising events and other promotional activities, do so.
- Suggested the NZRA (National) could offer an upfront financial incentive to kick-start a regional group.
- These groups might follow an 'affiliated club' or a 'regional branch' of NZRA approach. The affiliated club approach may require the regional group to become registered as a society.
- Alongside this, group structure might be quite informal. In previous years, most regions rejected notions of any formal structure and preferred to work as informal networks, email groups etc. There is no indication this has changed. It will be interesting to see if we can find a middle ground that meets the range of requirements from local style through to more formal requirements for insurance etc.

- Suggested the Canterbury-based core national committee disband and form into a Canterbury regional group.

Roles (include)

- Organise events, including championships on rotational basis
- Local training, promotion
- Operate within the national framework and Constitution/Rules

Getting going

- We thought and agreed that Marlborough and Canterbury are well placed to become test cases in setting up regional rogaining groups. Taranaki could be likewise (Nick?).

Administrative issues

Bank accounts:

- While it appears feasible to operate regional bank accounts and to report finances only in aggregated form at the level of national organisation, it may be a thankless task for the national treasurer to consolidate the suite of regional accounts.
- Further investigation needed to see how we can balance local flexibility against financial requirements of an incorporated Socy.

A paid national secretary/treasurer?

- Given the apparent reticence of individuals to administer a revised national/regional framework, the meeting agreed there could be case to engage a paid sec/treasurer. This would ensure clarity of role and accountability of delivery.

Public liability insurance

- Ensuring events unambiguously have cover for third party losses and damages through public liability insurance is the most testing requirement of any organisational structure. Current arrangements are that our policy covers events 'organised by the NZRA'. This is open to interpretation. Given our loose membership structure, it is unclear – and not easily testable – if a member organising an event that is not overtly promoted as an NZRA event is covered. Where this link is weak we assist organisers to create a one-off event policy. It appears all our events must demonstrably be NZRA events.
- Is a combination of using a NZRA indemnity form for each participant plus a per person event levy to cover insurance going back to NZRA indicative of a defensible relationship that would satisfy an insurer?
- Requires further investigation.

National/regional group relationships

- We need to better understand the nature of legal and practical relationships (benefits/costs) between parent (national) body and local group. A formal 'affiliated group' or 'regional branch' structure may for example make insurance arrangements more robust?

Mondo agreed to investigate how some models work in his region for kindred sports wrt insurance and other functions: e.g. NZ Bike and local mountain bike club

Next steps

- Determine level of buy-in from wider committee, possibly through a pre-AGM meeting in early February
- If supported (or concurrently), advise membership through website and seek feedback and engagement
- Motion to AGM February 2014

Sequence then may be to

- Resolved uncertainties about (1) insurance, (2) relationships between regional and national bodies (3) financial accounts
- Setup two regional groups on test basis (say Marlborough and Canterbury)

It should be feasible to have largely functional implementation of all components by February 2015. Implementation of any change will depend on buy-in and engagement by members.

Note that the above are suggestions; the committee is open to any alternative approaches that offer greater benefit.

Other business

NZ Championship events

Confirming agreements as follows (these can be entered into the rogaining calendar as tentative commitments):

2014: 8-9 November Central Otago, Ed Stevens, Highland Events
2015: 31 Oct – 1 Nov Marlborough, Mondo Kopua

Noted that suggestions have in the past been made that we avoid November as it inhibits school-aged and university-aged teams from being associated with either champs events or shorter ones run alongside them. In practice, we need to also factor in the availability of land and organisers, both crucial deciders in ’14 and ’15.

2016: (First Australasian Champs to be held in NZ; it would be the 4th Australasian champs). Venue and dates uncertain at this stage; organiser Tim Farrant. Likely to be eastern-central NI but more time needed on this one. Noted that a requirement of ARA is that dates are notified by two years before the event. If our event is to be early in the calendar year (as currently preferred) notification could be expected as early as Feb/March 2014. Given that a date is also largely dependent on a venue, such notification could be a challenge for us. If so, we should give earliest-warning of any delays.

Proposed Secondary Schools Rogaine Championship

Michael Wood advised NZRA of the NZOF approach to the NZ Secondary Schools Sports Council to operate a Championship rogaine starting next year, and the wider case behind it. For 2014 August is proposed, to be organised by Orienteering Bay of Plenty. Sue Scott and Robert Newbrook are contact points. The committee supports this concept and is willing to think-through how NZRA may contribute.

Resignation
Dave Laurie resigned from the committee of NZRA but indicated he is willing to continue to be involved with organising rogaines. Dave is a founding member of NZRA and a committee member and event organiser since its inception in 2002. We thank him very much and look forward to his ongoing practical role.

AGM 2014
No date was set but the Secretary proposes Monday 24 February. Towards improving national dialogue, we should try to make this an ‘e-hookup’ meeting.

G Hunter, Secretary, 19 December 2013